

There's a certain amount of irony in talking about man's effect on the wildlife of Lake Norman. It is, after all, a body of water that was created when men dammed a river and flooded over 32,000 acres of forest and farm land 35 years ago. Much of the wildlife that is here now would never have been here if man hadn't created the lake.

But even with this in mind, there's no denying that man's continued development of land around the lake is having an impact on animal species that live both in and around the lake.

Sgt. Brad Thorson of the N.C. Wildlife Resources Commission puts it another way. "Every stitch of land is being developed around the lake, and as each new piece of land is developed the wildlife is being forced to move or perish."

The job of the Wildlife Resources Commission, according to Thorson, is to preserve natural (hunting and fishing) resources for generations to come. Though Thorson typically addresses the needs of species populations as a whole, he also deals with individual animals. He says that our recent experience with an injured duckling (see "Lucky duck" on page 14) is not that unusual - he has found seagulls with fishing lures in their mouths and line wrapped around them.

"The state of people is improving around Lake Norman," says Thorson, "but the state of wildlife is in decline - we're taking their habitat." As the human population of the area continues to increase and trees continue to be cut down, there is increased interaction between humans and wildlife. Unfortunately for the animals, much of this interaction comes in the form of automobiles.

Beneath the surface

Fishery biologist Wayne Chapman of the N.C. Wildlife Resources Commission says that shoreline development also has a profound effect on the fish population. When people build on the lake they often clear more than the land, they also have fallen tree and debris removed from the water.

While this might be considered an improvement to some people, it's destroying the natural habitat of many fish such as panfish and bass. "This is not good for the fish," says Chapman,

"and unfortunately we're seeing more and more of this happening."

Another problem caused by new construction around the lake is soil runoff. Chapman says that these nutrients, which are good for your lawn, can be toxic to fish.

"We are seeing some conflict because of more and more uses of the shoreline," says Chapman. "We need to develop better shoreline management plans to make sure that one use doesn't seriously impact another."

In the air

Jim Miles, executive director of the Carolina Raptor Center, says that the land development has also had an effect on the raptor (bird of prey) population.

"To appreciate the raptors," he says, "people have to understand their role in keeping down the rodent and reptile population."

The Raptor Center took in 539

Vanishing Habitat

The state of wildlife on Lake Norman

by Richard Rudisill

At left, "Denver" the owl was hit by a truck in Denver four years ago and could not be returned to the wild. You can see him at the Carolina Raptor Center. PHOTO/RICHARD RUDISILL

Below, turtles are having to find creative ways to sun themselves now that people are removing fallen trees from the water. FILE PHOTO



injured and orphaned birds last year, many of which came from the Lake Norman area. Miles says that some of the raptors had been shot, but a larger percentage were injured after getting caught up in warehouses, buildings and chimneys.

While many raptors perish due to the loss of habitat, Miles points out that some have been able to adapt. "It's not

uncommon to see hawks sitting on the street lights of Interstate 77, looking for rodents on the interstate," he says.

On a positive note, he says that there has been a tremendous comeback in the raptor population since it hit its low point in the '70s.

The population decline was due to widespread use of DDT (insecticide), which was causing eggs not to hatch.